From: **Rob Reuss** robreuss@mac.com
Subject: Re: Following up re Vietnam website
Date: March 24, 2025 at 10:07 PM
To: Marc Weiss mweiss@weblab.org

Hey Marc,

Apologies for the slow response.

I'd really love to help out but at this point I'm in the run up to getting an initial version of my app published and I could not take the lead on the project.

I am happy to consult in terms of making a plan and if the path is to migrate the content to another system, I can help with transforming the content into a structured format (e.g. CSV, JSON) that can be imported into another system. I'd ask $50/hr but I'm limited to how much time I can devote as I mentioned.

If you haven't loaded the index.html file into your browser and explored the site you should do that. It's a fascinating time-capsule, in terms of user experience and navigation, given the non-linear, hyper-textual approach we used. If preserving that part of the experience is a part of your intent, cleaning up the original HTML so it displays reasonably well on modern, high resolution desktops and mobile devices is certainly an option, although it will present some accessibility issues in terms of text and image elements (some text is rendered as images) not properly adjusting for vision differences. As well, though the menu items are fine using a mouse they may present a problem on mobile devices for those with larger fingers because they are only 40px wide.

Alternatively, importing it into a modern content management system, such as WordPress, would prioritize perseveration of the underlying written content, but likely forsaking the non-linear experience for a navigation approach more in line with contemporary expectations, navigation that helps the user understand where they are, what they are looking at, and gives them a clear pathway to explore in a consistent and comprehensive way.

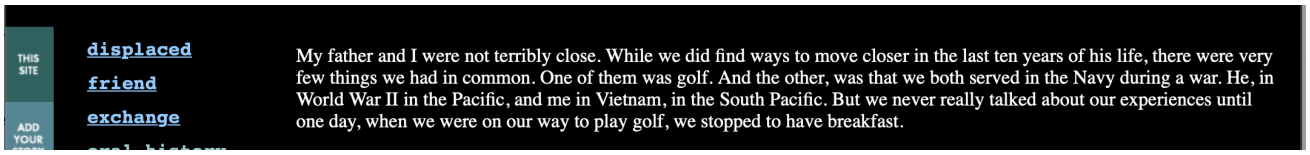
For example, see the attached screenshot. It's hard for the user to know what they're looking at and there is no navigation pathway out except resorting to one of the top level menu items. If they are in the middle of exploring they can use the back button, but if someone sent the page as a link, it would be a bit confusing what to do next. The navigation on the original site depends on the use of the back button, which is now widely considered bad practice as this point for a number of reasons related to context, breaking flow and creating accessibility problems.

I should note though that taking content designed to be presented non-linear way and making it employ a more common navigation approach may present some problems that I'm not foreseeing right now - it may require putting a square peg in a round hole.

I'd be happy to get on the phone and chat about this further - perhaps we can explore the archive a bit together on a zoom - and I can get a better sense of your goals in terms of balancing the preservation of the non-linear navigation with presenting the underlying content in a way more aligned with contemporary patterns. I can see the merits of both.

Best,

Rob



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All of a sudden the conversation became very serious. I told him something I had felt for a long time but had never said out loud. I said, "You are the lucky generation." He looked at me in kind of a very strange way. I went on to tell him that his was the last generation that grew up believing there was a man in the moon - I grew up knowing there had been a man on the moon; His was the last generation that grew up in rural communities untouched by modern technology, unknowing of all that is going on in the world. I grew up in the information age, knowing everything, seeing everything, watching history unfold in front of my well-worn TV eyes; his was the last generation that grew up having the full American dream intact; mine was the generation who saw the American dream tarnished by Watergate and other political corruption.

Finally, and this was when it got very serious, I said his was a generation who was able to come home after fighting in a war not only knowing what you did was necessary but everyone around you knew it too. My generation fought in a war we did not understand and when we came home, we were demonstrated against, spit on, yelled at, shunned, and left alone. We had no justification, no heroes, no protection of the heart, no treatment for the wound no one could see. We were left on our own to figure it out by ourselves, and many of us, unable to deal with the reality of what we did and what we saw, did the logical thing to survive-- the only thing we could do to survive-- we buried it. We buried it in the deep place inside where no one could see, no one could touch, no one could hurt. Some buried it so deep they withdrew from the world around us and have never been able to reenter.

It was one of the most interesting conversations I ever had with my father. He argued with me on every point except the last-- and when we got to that point, he looked at me and said, quietly, and simply, "You're right." And there was a very long pause after he said that - neither one of us said anything, and then we both had tears in our eyes. My father, because his son had been hurt and there was nothing he could do about it. And me, I had tears in my eyes because it was the first time I had admitted out loud to someone I had been wounded in 'Nam. It caught us both off guard. It was one of the few times I felt close to my father-- I am sure it was because we had shared a deep and significantly personal moment. We never talked about that conversation again, but I cherish that sharing only veterans can have, with one another. Especially when the veteran was my father.

Patrick Overton, Ph.D.
excerpt from Huntsville Memorial Dedication, Memorial Day, 1994 more▶

> On Mar 24, 2025, at 2:11 PM, Marc Weiss <mweiss@weblab.org> wrote:
>
> Hi Rob,
>
> I just realized I could email you in addition to DM'ing you on LinkedIn, which is kind of hit or miss.
>
> To save you time, here's what I wrote:
>
> "Hey Rob, they're on a very slow track so I'd love to go ahead and get it up on a server. Still own stories.org.
>
> I so much appreciate your offer to help out, and I'd love for you to take it on if you have time. But I don't expect you to do it for free."
>
> When you have a chance, please let me know what you need to be able to move forward.
>
> Thanks!
>
> Marc